

“I never realized sidewalks were a big deal”: A Case Study of a  
Community-Driven Sidewalk Audit Using Project Sidewalk - Li et. al.

**Takeaways:** The authors found that community-driven digital civics can successfully support accessibility advocacy and education while driving pro-social behavioral change! A key finding was the shift from addressing infrastructure issues remedially (fixing individual problems) to approaching them systemically through community efforts and existing community organizations (Girl Scouts). By distributing work among community members, the study showed that digital tools can facilitate engagement across all age groups and lead to significant knowledge gains and care regarding urban accessibility. **Strengths:** A major strength of the project is the tool design itself, which features an easy-to-use, interactive, color-coded map that serves as both a crowdsourced data collector and a resource for information seekers. I thought the use of “mapathons” was a smart and fun design choice that gathered large amounts of data quickly, while re-auditing processes helped ensure data quality, something that tends to be hard with subjective coding of data. **Weaknesses:** Because the tool is a visual search and labeling tool, it can be inaccessible to people who are blind, have low vision, or have upper-body motor disabilities (think even carpal tunnel). **Limitations and Questions:** Findings may not be representative of other communities that don’t have the same resources or sense of community (like having a Girl Scouts troop). Participation in using the tools also required a laptop, mouse, and internet connection, which could be a barrier in low-income communities. One overall question I have is, is advocacy legitimized by a digital tool? Does the use of technology make the advocacy seem more “professional” or valid to city councils compared to traditional manual audits? Unfortunately, I think it’s easier to pitch change with data and a product to back it up than to state why an issue matters to you specifically.

**Interesting Parts:** The part of the paper I found most interesting was the involvement of the Girl Scouts and the use of gamification to keep volunteers engaged. It was surprising to see how relevant the work became for participants: mapathons were fun enough that people continued contributing even after the events ended! I also thought the study did a good job of including the target population in the design process by having able-bodied scouts interact with community members with disabilities. Furthermore, the lack of consensus on what the most important accessibility issue is led data insights and visualizations to be crucial in deciding next steps to bring to the City Council. I also think that data exploration for the Girl Scouts really sparked their interest and determination to make a change. **Applications:** This study reminds us that when designing inclusive technology, prioritizing user agency can be rewarding. I think recruiting naturally interested parties results in having invested volunteers contributing higher quality data (even if reaudits are performed). Furthermore, this was a good example of how to turn user-centered design projects into actionable advocacy planning (city council presentation).